

Six Virtues on a Terrace: Kanazawa's Castle, Canals and Garden

Between two rivers on a raised terrace, a fortified Buddhist hall grew into a castle, a castle drew water uphill through a hand-dug canal, and a retired schoolyard became a garden judged to combine six virtues at once. This dossier traces Kanazawa's castle town from a 1546 place name to the samurai lanes and teahouse street a visitor walks today.



金沢城下（金沢市）

In this dossier

1. A history of the district (6 chapters, about 1500 words)
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Written in English from Japanese library sources — chiefly books digitised by the National Diet Library — and official records. Superscript numbers point to the numbered sources at the end, with page frames for the digitised books.

A Terrace Between Two Rivers

The ground this district sits on is almost entirely river terrace and alluvial fan, built up where the Sai River and the Asano River, running roughly parallel, drop from the hills toward the Sea of Japan — the classic setting local histories describe as the terrace between the two rivers. The place name itself is first recorded in 1546, in a diary entry for the twenty-ninth day of the tenth month naming a "Kanazawa-bōsha," a hall of that name; once the hall was gone, the name passed to the fortress and then the town that grew on its site. One well-known local legend explains it differently, tracing "Kanazawa" — literally "gold marsh" — to a stream on the Kodatsuno terrace where a humble digger remembered as Imohori Tōgorō is said to have washed gold from the gravel.¹

The fortress itself began as a temple stronghold. Hongan-ji's third patriarch Kakunyo is said to have built a small hall on what became the castle's inner citadel; the Ikkō-ikki, Buddhist militants who grew powerful around it, killed the Kaga military governor Togashi Masachika in 1488 and fortified the hall with earthworks and a timber palisade, a stronghold known as Oyama Castle. For roughly ninety years a succession of temple stewards held it, until Oda Nobunaga's general Sakuma Morimasa seized it by force in 1580.¹

From a Militants' Fortress to a Daimyo's Castle

Morimasa's tenure lasted barely four years: he backed the losing side when Toyotomi Hideyoshi turned on Shibata Katsuie in 1583, was captured after the battle of Shizugatake, and lost the castle he had only just begun to fortify properly. Hideyoshi granted the district instead to Maeda Toshiie, who moved in from Nanao Castle on the Noto peninsula. An 1894 domain history remembers Toshiie as generous and broad-minded, a soldier who fought dozens of battles under Oda Nobunaga without a serious miscalculation, and a man frugal enough that he kept the same leather-wrapped sword hilt even after rising to senior court rank; when Nobunaga was killed in 1582 Toshiie wanted to avenge him at once but was held back by troubles closer to home, and later served under Hideyoshi instead. It was Toshiie's heir, Toshinaga, who began the castle's transformation in 1592 — quarrying stone from Mount Tomuro, digging the great moat still remembered as Hyakken-bori ("hundred-ken moat") to the south-east, laying underground pipes to bring water inside the walls, and giving the fortress the name it has kept since: Kanazawa Castle.¹⁶

Successive lords kept building: an inner town-encircling moat by 1599, an outer one by 1610, and in 1631 a reorganisation that made the Ninomaru the castle's functional centre. The castle's main keep did not survive that century: built as a proper tenshu under Toshiie, it burned in a lightning strike in 1605, was rebuilt as a three-storey tower in its place, and burned again in a great fire of 1759 — after which it was never rebuilt at all, which is why Kanazawa Castle's skyline today is turrets and gates rather than the tall keep visitors expect from Himeji or Matsumoto. Fourteen generations of the Maeda family held the castle for 287 years, from Toshiie to the last lord, Yoshiyasu, who surrendered its lands to the new government in 1869; after the domain's abolition the army stationed a garrison, then an infantry regiment, then a full division headquarters on the grounds, demolishing what it no longer needed and losing the Ninomaru's remaining halls to a fire of its own in 1881.¹

Water for a Castle and Its Samurai

None of this worked without water carried uphill. The year after the 1631 reorganisation, engineers drew water from the Sai River, raised it at Kodatsuno and channelled it into the castle's moats — the Tatsumi Canal, whose builder local tradition names as Itaya Heishirō, a man said to have died a violent death and to be enshrined, still, at a Hachiman shrine in what is now Kahoku district. A second, older waterway, the Ōno-shō Canal, is more contested: town histories variously credit it to a Maeda retainer named Tominaga Sataro working in the 1570s–80s, or push its origin back to the 980s under a provincial governor, Togashi Tadayori, with Tominaga only improving an existing channel — even a 1995 study of the city's canals concludes plainly that no one now knows for certain.²

What is not contested is who lived where. Domain-era Kanazawa gave over most of Honda-machi, Nagamachi, Sansha and Hikosomachi, along with large parts of several other districts, to samurai residences — by one contemporary reckoning, samurai land covered roughly three times the area given to merchants and townspeople. Nagamachi's canal-fed lanes and earthen-walled compounds are the clearest surviving trace of that division, and its mud walls still receive a distinctly local kind of winter care: woven straw mats, threaded with bamboo and tied to the roof beams and stone footings, to keep snow from grinding the clay away. Individual households did this on their own for perhaps two centuries; the city itself organised the work for the first time only in 1986, covering about 248 metres of wall, before extending the programme to the whole of Nagamachi's remaining walls the following year. Not every former

samurai residence stayed frozen in the Edo period: after the domain fell, one retainer, Abe Hekikai, built five pottery kilns on his own former residential land and gathered more than eighty workers trained in the old Kutani tradition to produce ware for export, a Meiji-era industrial reuse of samurai land that this district's local history treats as the start of Kanazawa's own Kutani-ware production.¹³

Six Virtues of a Garden

The garden above the castle's southern approach went through as many changes of use as the castle itself. Its lower half, once a lotus pond, housed a Confucian scholar under Lord Toshinaga in the early 1600s and a construction office under Toshitsune later that century; Lord Tsunanori built a pavilion there in 1676. The higher ground had belonged to two senior retainer families until 1791, when Lord Harunaga built two schools for his retainers on the vacated site, with a dividing wall between the schools and the old lotus garden. It was only in 1822, when Lord Narinaga moved both schools elsewhere and tore the wall down to build himself a retirement villa on the enlarged grounds, that the statesman Matsudaira Sadanobu — invited, by tradition, to name the newly unified garden — reached for a twelfth-century Chinese essay on the gardens of Luoyang and chose Kenroku-en, "the garden that combines six [virtues]": spaciousness, seclusion, artifice, antiquity, water and a view. The domain's fall opened it to the public for the first time in 1874.¹⁴

Much of what a visitor now walks past dates from exactly the transformations that history records: the Yūgao-tei pavilion and its waterfall from Lord Narinaga's rebuilding; Kasumi-ga-ike pond, fed by a curving stream that is, again, water carried from the Sai River along the Tatsumi Canal; an ice-storage pit on the hill behind, dug to keep winter snow through the summer. Even the garden's trees were not exempt from the twentieth century's demands: a Hokuriku newspaper of 24 June 1945 recorded that Kenroku-en's own pine trees were being tapped for pine-root oil, a wartime substitute for aircraft fuel, in the war's last desperate months.⁴⁵

An Old Quarter Renamed

Kanazawa's teahouse district on the far bank of the Asano River carries a name younger than it looks. For most of the twentieth century, publications and residents alike called it by a plainer, older term — the "old eastern quarter" — a name that, by the 1980s, tourism promoters felt carried too much of the licensed pleasure district's old reputation. A new name, Higashi Chaya-gai, "the eastern teahouse street," began appearing in print around 1989 and had become the standard usage in guidebooks within two or three years, according to a 2010 newspaper account of the change. The wooden lattice-fronted teahouses themselves are older than their present name; only the marketing is a product of the district's late-twentieth-century reinvention as a destination rather than a trade.⁷

Reading the Ground Today

Kanazawa's own good fortune in the summer of 1945 — a city that, unlike so many others of its size, ended the war with its castle town's streets essentially intact — is often noted and rarely explained in the sources available here; what can be said is that the city was still functioning normally enough in June of that year to be milling pine roots for fuel rather than clearing rubble. That survival is why the layers described above remain legible in the same few square kilometres: Nagamachi's mud walls and their winter straw coats, the Tatsumi Canal still running toward Kenroku-en exactly as it did in the seventeenth century, and a teahouse street whose buildings are Edo- and Meiji-era originals wearing a Heisei-era name.¹⁵⁷

Some traces are smaller and easy to miss: the absence of a tall central keep at the castle is itself a record of the 1759 fire that never got rebuilt, and behind Kenroku-en's ornamental stream lies a still-functioning stretch of a four-hundred-year-old water-supply canal, not merely a landscaped brook. The Hokuriku Shinkansen's extension to Kanazawa Station in 2015 changed how most visitors now arrive, but not the ground itself: the terrace between the two rivers, and the water led across it by hand centuries before any railway existed, still shape the walk from the station to the castle gate.¹⁷

Timeline

1488	Ikkō-ikki forces kill the Kaga governor Togashi Masachika and fortify a Hongan-ji hall as Oyama Castle. ¹
1546	The earliest written record of the name "Kanazawa" (a hall, Kanazawa-bōsha) appears in a diary entry. ¹
1580	Oda Nobunaga's general Sakuma Morimasa seizes Oyama Castle. ¹
1583	Maeda Toshiie is granted the district after Morimasa's capture at Shizugatake. ¹
1592	Maeda Toshinaga rebuilds the castle and renames it Kanazawa Castle. ¹
1632	The Tatsumi Canal begins carrying Sai River water into the castle's moats. ¹
1676	Lord Tsunanori builds a pavilion in the future Kenroku-en's lower garden. ¹
1791	Lord Harunaga builds the Meirindō and Keibukan schools on the garden's upper ground. ¹
1822	The schools move out; Matsudaira Sadanobu names the unified garden Kenroku-en. ¹⁴
1869	The last Maeda lord, Yoshiyasu, surrenders the domain's lands; the castle is vacated. ¹
1874	Kenroku-en opens to the public for the first time. ¹
24 June 1945	A local newspaper records pine-root oil being extracted from Kenroku-en's pines for aircraft fuel. ⁵
c. 1986–87	The city organises its first official straw-mat (komo-kake) protection of Nagamachi's mud walls, then extends it citywide in the district. ³
c. 1989–92	"Higashi Chaya-gai" replaces the older "old eastern quarter" as the district's public name. ⁷

Walking notes

Places to stand and look, in walking order. Straight-line distances only; check today's access and opening before you go.

- 1

Kanazawa Castle Park, Hyakken-bori and Ishikawa Gate 金沢城公園・百間堀・石川門. Walk the line of the great south-eastern moat Toshinaga's engineers dug in 1592; the surviving Ishikawa Gate and reconstructed turrets stand on ground the Maeda family held for fourteen generations.¹
- 2

Kenroku-en, Kasumi-ga-ike and the Tatsumi Canal inlet 兼六園・霞ヶ池・辰巳用水. Follow the curving stream into Kasumi-ga-ike pond back to its source: Sai River water still arriving via the same Tatsumi Canal built in 1632, feeding a garden named for six virtues in 1822.¹⁴
- 3

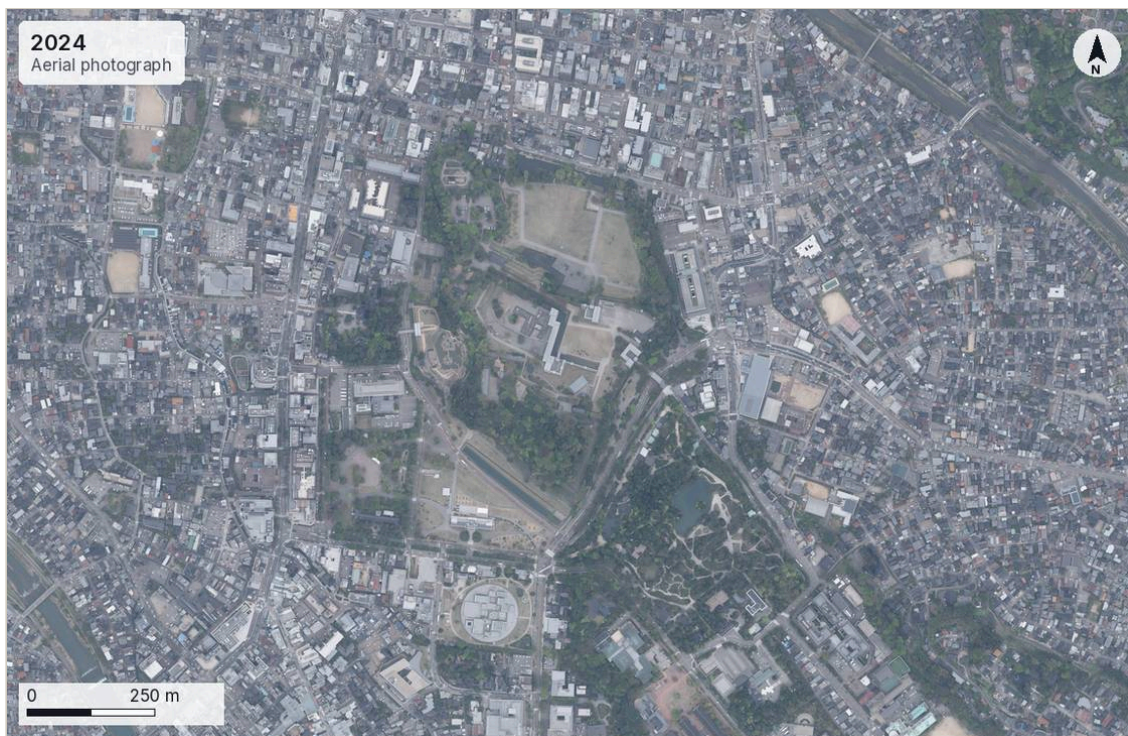
Nagamachi samurai district and its canal 長町武家屋敷跡. Earthen-walled lanes on ground that was almost entirely samurai residence land under the domain; look for the straw matting bound to the walls each December, a practice the city itself has organised since 1886.¹³
- 4

Higashi Chaya-gai ひがし茶屋街. Lattice-fronted teahouses on the Asano River's far bank; the buildings are old, but the name that markets them to visitors today only became standard around 1990.⁷

The same ground, 1961–1969 and 2024



1961–1969 aerial photograph — GSI Tiles *ort_old10*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. North is up; the frame is identical in both images.



2024 annual orthophoto — GSI Tiles *nendophoto2024*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. Capture dates within a mosaic can differ from place to place.

How to compare. Anchor on features that rarely move — river banks, rail lines, shrine and temple grounds, main roads — then look for what changed around them. Differences in tone come from film, camera and season, not from the land itself.

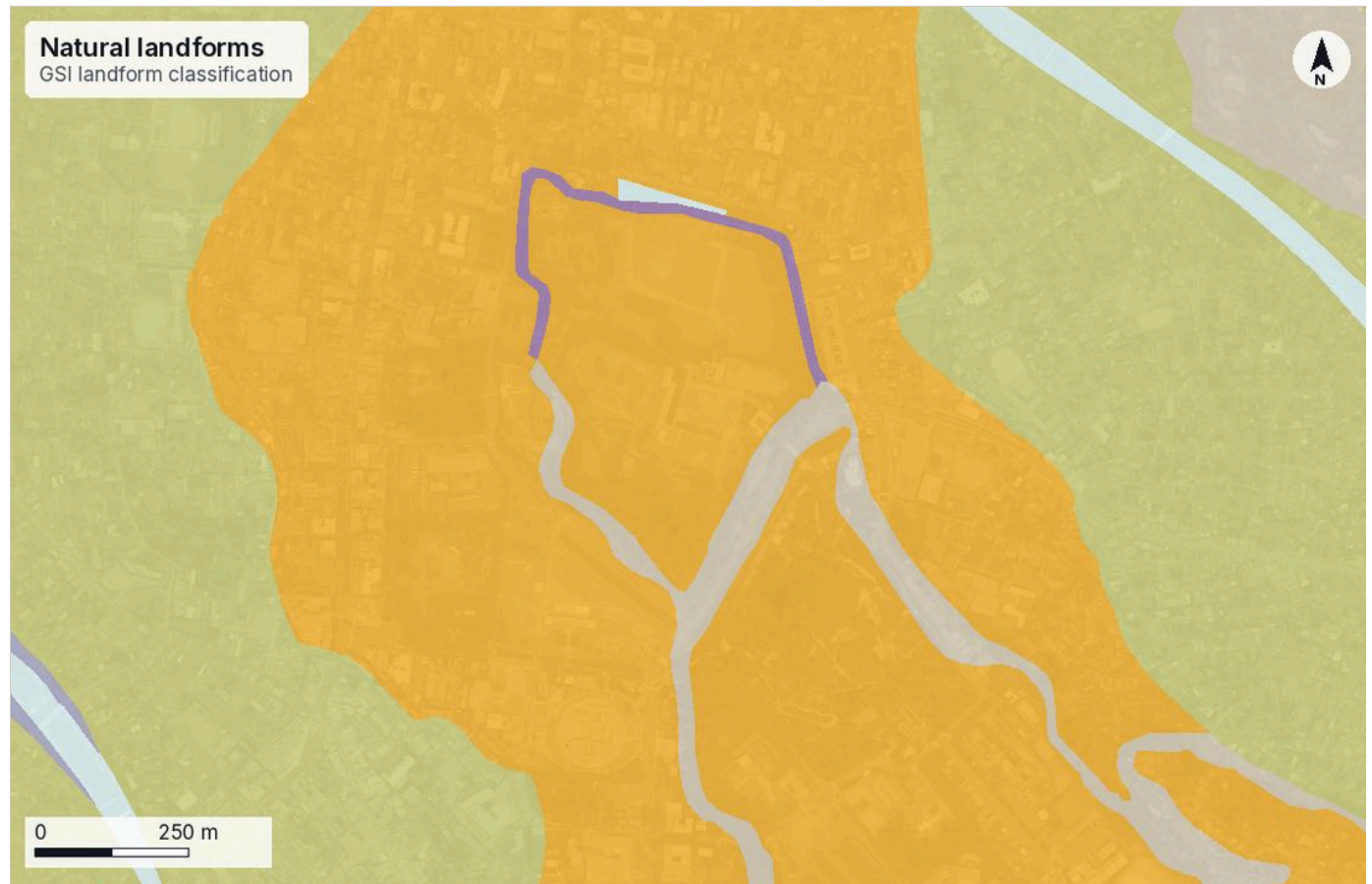
The decades in between

Every further GSI series that covers the same frame, oldest first. Each series is a compilation: photographs within one series were taken on different dates, which is why seams and changes of tone can appear inside a frame.



1974-1978 · GSI Tiles *gazo1*, processed

Rivers, shorelines and terraces



Natural landforms as classified by GSI, over a recent aerial photograph in gray. Dark blue outlines mark former river channels.

■ Plateaus and terraces 50%	■ Alluvial fan 41%
■ Mountain and hill slopes 6.2%	■ Water 2.0%
■ Cliffs and terrace scarps 0.5%	

What the main landforms mean

Plateaus and terraces (50%). Flat ground standing in steps above its surroundings, left behind as the land around it was eroded. River flooding is rarely a threat unless the terrace is only slightly above the river; watch the slopes at its edges. Firm ground: shaking is relatively weak and liquefaction is unlikely.

Alluvial fan (41%). Gently sloping ground spreading fan-like from a valley mouth, built from sediment dropped by floods. Floodwater from the mountains, and debris flows near the valley mouth. Relatively firm ground; a slight liquefaction tendency on the lower fan.

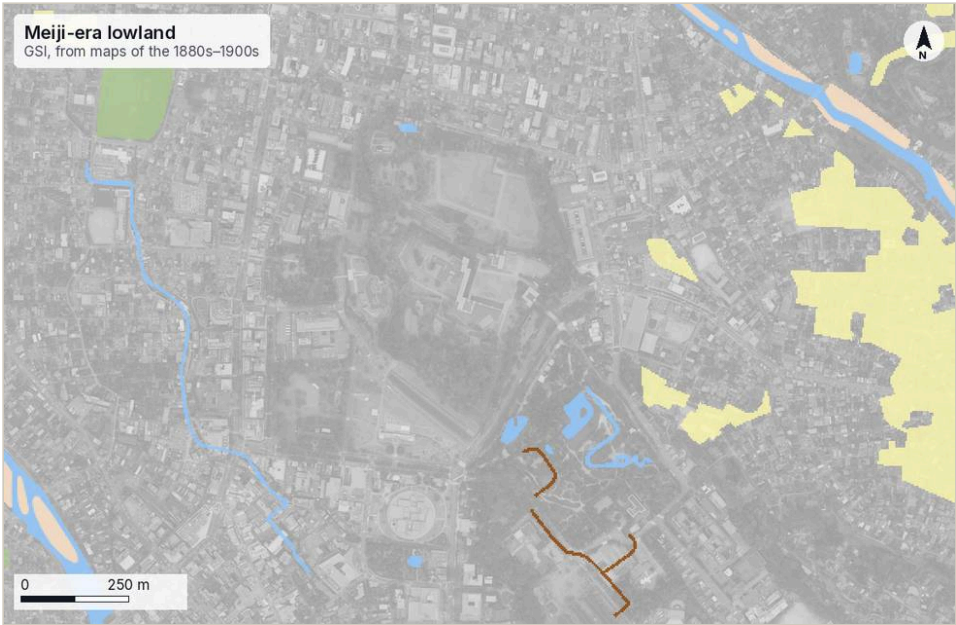
Mountain and hill slopes (6.2%). Ridges, valleys and fairly steep ground, including terrace-scarp slopes and volcanic ground. Heavy rain or earthquakes can trigger slope failures, debris flows and landslides.

Descriptions translated and condensed from GSI's landform-classification legend. They describe tendencies of each landform type, not the condition of any individual plot.

Fill, reclamation and the fields beneath the town



Hatching: man-made ground as classified by GSI. Teal outlines: former sea, river or pond. Dark blue outlines: former river channels.



GSI “Meiji-era lowland” data, traced from topographic maps of the 1880s–1900s; GSI warns that positions can be off by a considerable distance, especially in the Kanto and Kinki regions. Only low, wet or open ground was traced: towns, dry fields and forest of the period are left blank.

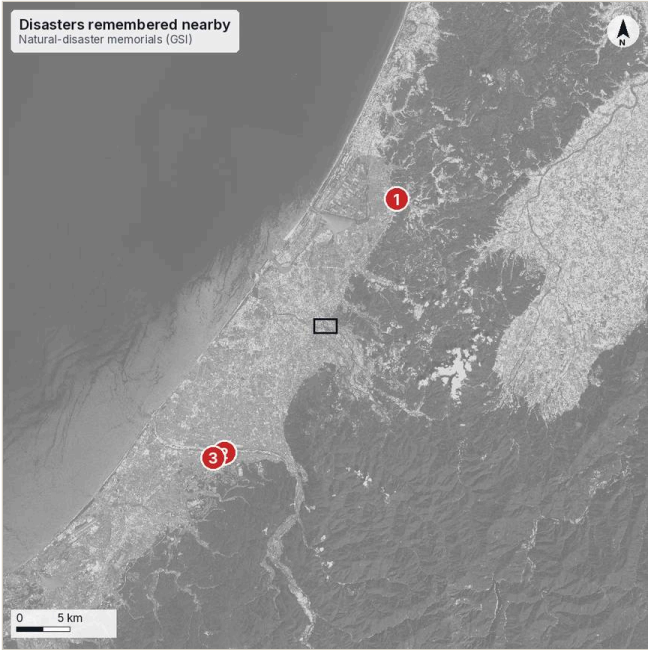
Man-made ground

 Cut ground 0.9%

Meiji-era lowland

-  Rice paddy 5.7%
-  River, pond or sea 1.6%
-  Uncultivated land 0.9%
-  Sand and gravel 0.7%

Memorials to natural disasters nearby



Numbered memorials; the black rectangle is the study area of this brief. Frame 60 km across.

Fewer than three memorials stand within 3 km of the study area, so the nearest ones within 30 km are listed.

	Memorial	Disaster	Erected	Distance
1	Monument to the recovery from the 1964 Tsubata River flood 災害復興記念碑	San'in-Hokuriku heavy rain (Jul 1964) · flood	1969	13.5 km
2	Memorial to the 1896 Tedorì River flood at Yamada 水害記念碑	Tedorì River flood (3 Aug 1896) · flood	1899	15.1 km
3	Memorial boulders left by the 1896 flood 水害記念石	Flood (2–3 Aug 1896) · flood	unknown	16.1 km

What the memorials record

1. **Monument to the recovery from the 1964 Tsubata River flood.** Torrential rain in July 1964 made the Tsubata River overflow, killing 3 people and flooding more than 2,500 houses in all. Repairs and a thorough improvement of the river were completed in 1969, and the monument was erected to mark the recovery.
2. **Memorial to the 1896 Tedorì River flood at Yamada.** On the morning of 3 August 1896, after rain from the previous day, the Tedorì River embankments broke everywhere. In Yamada 2 houses were swept away, every house was flooded and most fields were lost, but a bamboo-covered embankment (jibushin) held back the torrent so homes were not fully submerged. The stone warns: "Beside a river, floods are hard to avoid."
3. **Memorial boulders left by the 1896 flood.** The flood of 2–3 August 1896 was "seven parts mud to three parts water": rice fields became a riverbed of gravel, roads were buried in mud and houses were crushed. Three large boulders the flood carried here were placed in the shrine grounds as memorial stones.

Source: GSI Natural Disaster Memorials (自然災害伝承碑). English names and notes are Japan Time Atlas translations and summaries of GSI's Japanese descriptions; the memorials' own inscriptions may say more. "Erected" is the year GSI records for the monument.

Sources

1. 加越能史談会 (Kaetsunō Historical Discussion Society), *金沢故蹟誌* [Record of Kanazawa's Historic Sites], 1923; NDL frames 10, 11, 12, 20, 26, 27. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/963936/1/10> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: The city's block-by-block samurai/merchant land division; the full castle history from the Ikkō-ikki's Oyama Castle through Sakuma Morimasa and Maeda Toshiie/Toshinaga; Kenroku-en's site history from Renchi-tei to its 1822 naming; the Tatsumi Canal and its builder Itaya Heishirō.
2. レファレンス協同データベース：大野庄用水について [Collaborative Reference Database: on the Ōno-shō Canal], 金沢市立玉川図書館 (Kanazawa Tamagawa Library), via NDL. https://crd.ndl.go.jp/reference/detail?page=ref_view&id=1000190214, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The contested origins of the Ōno-shō Canal, citing three named local histories that disagree on date and builder.
3. レファレンス協同データベース：長町の武家屋敷の薦掛けについて [Collaborative Reference Database: on komo-kake at Nagamachi's samurai residences], 金沢市立玉川図書館 (Kanazawa Tamagawa Library), via NDL. https://crd.ndl.go.jp/reference/detail?page=ref_view&id=1000331014, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The straw-mat wall-covering technique, its roughly two-century history as an individual practice, and the city's own organised programme from 1986.
4. 北陸観光社 (Hokuriku Kankōsha), *兼六園写真大観* [Grand Photographic View of Kenroku-en], 1939; NDL frames 1, 2, 3. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1111992/1/2> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: The explanation of Kenroku-en's name, attributed to Matsudaira Sadanobu and a Song-dynasty Chinese essay on the gardens of Luoyang, and the surviving name-plaque at the garden's gate.
5. レファレンス協同データベース：兼六園の松根油について [Collaborative Reference Database: on pine-root oil from Kenroku-en], レファレンス協同データベース (answering library not specified in the record retrieved), via NDL. https://crd.ndl.go.jp/reference/detail?page=ref_view&id=1000089774, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Confirmation, via a named 1945 newspaper and two later Kenroku-en histories, that the garden's pine trees were tapped for wartime aircraft-fuel substitute.
6. 北陸教育社 (Hokuriku Education Society), *加賀史談* [Discourses on Kaga History], 1894; NDL frames 10, 11. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/764553/1/11> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: A character sketch of Maeda Toshiie: his temperament, frugality, service under Oda Nobunaga, and reaction to Nobunaga's death in 1582.
7. レファレンス協同データベース：東山ひがし地区の呼称の変化について [Collaborative Reference Database: on the change of name of the Higashiyama-Higashi district], 金沢市立玉川図書館 (Kanazawa Tamagawa Library), via NDL. https://crd.ndl.go.jp/reference/detail?page=ref_view&id=1000246530, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The district's older name "old eastern quarter," the reasons for renaming it, and the dates (c.1989-92) the name Higashi Chaya-gai became standard, citing a 2010 newspaper article.

Further reading

- *稿本金沢市史* (金沢市, *multiple volumes, 1920s*) — The city's own detailed draft history; the education-history volume is open online, but other volumes covering general and political history, which would extend this dossier considerably, were not located under a working pid in this session. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/951544> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login))
- *金城勝覧図誌* (平岩晋 著, 1908) — An illustrated Meiji-era guide to Kanazawa's scenic sites, with full-text search hits on the Tatsumi Canal; listed as open online, but its NDL Lab record returned a server error on every attempt in this session. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/764595> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login))
- *城下町金沢学術研究* (金沢市, 2010) — The city's own modern academic research volume on the castle town; its NDL Lab record also returned a server error in this session despite being listed as open access. <https://ndlsearch.ndl.go.jp/search?cs=bib&keyword=%E5%9F%8E%E4%B8%8B%E7%94%BA%E9%87%91%E6%B2%A2%E5%AD%A6%E8%A1%93%E7%A0%94%E7%A9%B6> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login))

Where a Deep Research request would go next

- **Hatta Yoichi's Kanazawa origins and any verifiable connection between his upbringing and his later career as the engineer of Taiwan's Chianan (Wushantou) irrigation system** — Kanazawa City's Furusato Ijinkan (museum of native sons and daughters) and the city's own archives. Contact the museum directly for its biographical materials; this dossier could not verify the connection from any source opened in this session and treats it as unconfirmed.
- **A documented explanation for Kanazawa's escape from air raids in 1945 (target lists, weather, or postwar accounts)** — US National Archives (20th Air Force target-selection records) and the Ishikawa Prefectural Library's local history division. Search NARA's catalogue for 20th Air Force target folders covering Ishikawa Prefecture; ask the prefectural library for its own compiled wartime record.
- **Primary building-by-building records of Nagamachi's and Higashi Chaya's Edo- and Meiji-era construction dates** — Kanazawa City's cultural properties division and the Ishikawa Prefectural Archives. Request the preservation-district survey reports prepared when each area was designated a traditional building group.
- **The full case for and against the Ōno-shō Canal's disputed origin date, beyond the summary in the reference-library answer used here** — Kanazawa City Museum library and Ishikawa Prefectural Library, for the three histories the CRD answer cites (金沢用水散歩, 金沢古蹟志, 金沢水道五十年史). Request these three titles directly; they are not confirmed as available in the NDL Digital Collections.
- **The Hokuriku Shinkansen extension's effect on Kanazawa's castle-town district specifically (visitor numbers, land use) since 2015** — Kanazawa City's tourism and statistics divisions, and JR West's own corporate history materials. Request the city's annual tourism statistics reports and JR West's published Hokuriku Shinkansen history.

Caveats

- This dossier could not verify, from any source opened in this session, a specific link between the engineer Hatta Yoichi and Kanazawa beyond his general association with the city; that claim is treated as unconfirmed and left out of the narrative rather than stated as fact.

- The reasons Kanazawa avoided major air-raid damage in 1945 are not explained in any source read for this dossier; only the fact that the city and Kenroku-en were functioning normally as of June 1945 is used, not a specific reason for the city's escape.
- The Hokuriku Shinkansen's 2015 extension to Kanazawa is stated as background knowledge rather than a claim drawn from a source opened and read in this session; a fact-checker should confirm the exact date against JR West's own materials.
- Several internet-accessible NDL items that would likely deepen this dossier — an illustrated 1908 Kanazawa guide and the city's own 2010 academic study of the castle town among them — returned server errors from the NDL Lab API throughout this session and so are listed in [furtherReading](#) rather than cited as sources.
- The Ōno-shō Canal's date and builder are genuinely disputed among the local histories cited in S2; this dossier reports the dispute rather than choosing one account.

Digitised books are cited, not reproduced: the page frames let you open the same page in the NDL Digital Collections. Aerial photographs, landform and memorial data: GSI, processed by Japan Time Atlas. This experimental edition is a draft for testing the product and has not had independent fact-checking.